fastest-growing urban areas. Of the six Indian cities that were listed, four were from Kerala—Malappuram, Kozhikode, Kollam and Thrissur. The others were Surat in Gujarat and Tiruppur in Tamil Nadu. Malappuram, in fact, topped the rankings, with a 44 per cent change between 2015 and 2020. It provoked industrialist Anand Mahindra to tweet: "Good to see that the fastest growing in India are not the monster metropolises, Mumbai, Delhi, Kolkata etc. When smaller towns and cities grow, it signals that a wider distribution of wealth and job opportunities is underway. We need more smaller towns to Rise!"

The Driving Force

What has changed? Experts attribute the rise of the small town to rapid urbanisation and the appearance of education centres across the country, which is enabling both entrepreneurship and skill enhancement. Financial consultant Ashvin Parekh estimates that as many as 230 such education centres, or regions, have emerged across the country since the early 1990s. India also has 3,000 incubation centres currently, which enable new business to stand on their own feet at the earliest. The mushrooming of professional colleges and technical institutes in small urban centres has widened the country's skill base, making it possible for companies to set up world-class manufacturing facilities anywhere in the country, without having to worry about attracting talent from top institutes alone.

Parekh discerns two clear kinds of individuals to track in these places. The first are those who are getting a better education and entering new areas of businesses. Their business models find good backing from venture capitalists and private equity players. The second are the traditionally wealthy who are putting in their money to fund new businesses in their home towns and cities. "Entrepreneurs in these places get the initial capital they require to drive their businesses from other wealthy entrepreneurs. Gone are the days when such



MK PATNAIK

BRAHMANANDAM POTRU, 69
Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh

Company	Net Worth
Devi Sea Foods Limited	**Rs 3,500 crore**

Sea Farer

The third of five children of a paddy and tobacco farmer in the Godavari delta, Brahmanandam Potru knew the vagaries of agriculture were not for him. He studied commerce and for a while took up contract work, first for the government and later for the upcoming Vizag steel plant.

Soon enough, he realised his fortunes lay elsewhere. "Visakhapatnam was a fish landing hub," he recalls, "and the city was abuzz with seafood trade." Yet there were few players from the state in the export and processing business. He discovered that the Indian Black Tiger shrimp commanded a premium, but was being sold in zero value-added forms and only to Japan. Brahmanandam trained his sights on the US market, "which had a great appetite for value-added shrimp in its Tier 1 food service and retail outlets".

Devi Sea Foods, (DSF), his flagship company, started earning profits from the year it was launched—1992. To offer better services to US customers and eliminate middle layers in the supply chain, he set up DSF's distribution subsidiary—Devi Sea Foods Inc—in the US in 2005. Among his customers today is food distributing giant and Fortune 500 company Sysco Corp.

–Amarnath K. Menon